



BINEESH (LEFT) WAS KILLED IN GANG RIVALRY AND AMONG THOSE ARRESTED WAS SOBHA JOHN, THE FIRST WOMAN IN THE STATE TO BE BOOKED UNDER THE GOONDA ACT

why did the young billionaire travel with three prominent criminals? Paul's fellow passengers—Praveen, Omprakash and Rajesh—have a number of murder cases against them and were on the run. "Initial probe does not indicate a pre-planned attack. An accidental brawl that occurred on the road between Paul and his friend, and another group led to the murder," says Vinson M. Paul, inspector general of police, Ernakulam range.

Paul was clearly the latest victim of the rising number of paid killer squads in Kerala despite the state's relatively better record in maintaining law and order. Known in the state as "quotation gangs", these contract killers kill or maim for a quoted price and are commonly used to settle political, business or personal scores. Because of the immense political and police support that these gangs enjoy, many known criminals have been roaming free despite warrants issued against them.

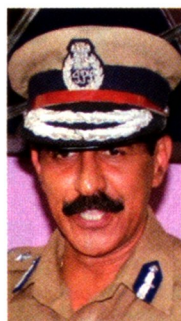
Adding a political twist to the tale,

M. Liju, Youth Congress president, says, "The two criminals who were following Paul have direct links with the ruling CPI(M) and Home Minister Kodyeri Balakrishnan." Omprakash was a member of CPI(M) student and youth body Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI), he adds. The organisation has since clarified that though he was a member, Omprakash was dismissed after his criminal activities came to light.

According to sources, Paul's murder was indeed caused by business rivalry. Paul was heading the Group's

“The murder doesn't look planned but the result of a sudden altercation.”

VINSON M. PAUL
IGP, ERNAKULAM RANGE



hospitality division and had set up a couple of resorts in the Alappuzha coastal district, which is Kerala's hottest tourist destination. Demand for land on the coastal Alappuzha is so high that the real estate groups have been using paid criminal gangs for acquiring land in Thiruvananthapuram, Alappuzha and Ernakulam where the land value has gone up by 500 per cent in the past three years.

As per police figures, there are 527 listed criminals in the state against whom arrest warrants have been issued, of which only 265 have been arrested so far. Of these 527 criminals, 66 have more than 10 cases each registered against them, but only 17 have been arrested. Even a few women have been arrested under the Goonda Act. "The gangs have grown with political and police support. We need a KPS Gill-style cleansing operation to clear the state," says C.P. Nair, retired state chief secretary.

In the last few years, criminal incidents, including murders, committed by organised gangs have been on the rise in Kerala. In June this year, Althara Bineesh, a known criminal, was killed by a rival gang on a busy Capital street in broad daylight. Among those arrested was Sobha John, the first woman in the state to be booked under the Goonda Act. She is also an accused in the case involving assault of the head priest of Sabarimala four years ago, and a sex racket case. Bineesh's killing was an act of revenge against the murder of another top contract killer, Mottamoodu Shaji, a few months ago. In a case of business rivalry in 2005, a paid criminal gang had deliberately rammed a truck into a Tata Safari car on a busy section of National Highway 47 at Kanichukulangara near Alappuzha, killing its three passengers who were working with the Everest Group, a money lending firm. Never before has Kerala witnessed such a volatile crime scenario. God's own country has come to a rather sorry pass. ■